Chapter Six

History of mankind [1]

How modern human surfaced from nowhere or somewhere in pre-historic period will always keep this mystery a controversy amongst evolutionists and creationists. We know that history of earth is divided in prehistoric and historic periods. The probable dividing line between the two is around 3200 BC. It is accepted that the events in historic part can be traced with some accuracy with the help of modern tools. But when it comes to tracing events in prehistoric times, it becomes difficult as tracing them with available tools is extremely difficult. In such circumstances they can rightly be termed speculative. Speculations invite disagreements which creates difference of opinion. In such circumstance, living in the 21st century, it is prudent for both sides to keep a space for the opposite views; or better still, fill the space with an alternate view that can bridge the gap between the two. It is in this context where one can see Sufism playing its role.

How?

Studying the speculative prehistoric events pertaining to mankind, it has been theorized that the fossil remains of first hominid, a man-like primate suggest that this creature known as Ramapithecus lived 12 million to 14 million years ago. It is presumed to be the ancestor of modern apes and lived on ground adapting itself to open grass[2]. Ramapithecus was followed by Australopithecus which appeared around 3.9 million years ago [3][4][5]. It went through evolutionary phases devising a series of species for another 3 million years. While passing through these phases, structural changes kept on appearing in its physique and social behaviour. Those changes were;

1. Its brain capacity increased from 450 cc to 525 cc,
2. Its average height increased from 3'-6" and to 5',
3. The prominent sagital crest on its skull with strong jaw muscles attached to it underwent gradual changes.

4. The heavier jaw bone with large molar teeth started receding with diminishing canine teeth,
5. It remained herbivorous and ate tough, hard to chew plants.
6. It became fully bipedal; the male stayed a little taller and heavier than the female because of their differing roles.
7. It gave no indication of speech capability.
8. And, somewhere along in its last million years' journey when it came out of forest into open grassland, it discovered club as defensive weapon to counter its predators.

As the events are related to prehistoric period, controversy exists on Australopithecus being the common ancestor of both ape and human. This speculation is based on a genome viewpoint, which suggests only 2 percent difference between modern man and the modern apes. On physical point of view, the greatest difference between the two is in locomotion. Humans walk upright which came about when hominid came out of jungle and adopted itself to plains. Its facial feature changed toward the modern appearance much later about 100,000 years ago. Before that, the face of earlier hominid was much more apelike [6].

From a social viewpoint, modern man and modern apes are quite similar in some aspects. For example, the sexual practices between the two are quite similar. Although homosexual activity is more common in apes than in human. This in case of human is about 10%.

Before 1972, most experts regarded Australopithecus as the fore-runner of man. However, the situation became complicated when that year Richard Leaky discovered a skull and leg bones of a man-like creature in Kenya. It was about 2.5 million years old and was considerably advanced than Australopithecus. His leg bones and size of skull indicated that it was about 5 feet tall, could walk upright and probably more intelligent. It was labelled the `1470 Man' [7].

At the same time, another tool making creature, 'Homo Habilis,' was found in Tanzania. The implication of these findings is that as Australopithecus co-existed with `1470 Man' and 'Homo

Habilis', and was less advanced than either of them, it cannot have been man's ancestor. Because of such findings, some authorities call Australopithecus an evolutionary `dead end'. The controversies continue.

Despite the controversies, the evolutionists speculate that evolution carried on in following manner.

Homo Habilis: It is generally believed that Australopithecus was followed by Homo Habilis which lasted between 2.4 million to 1.2 million years ago. The species is also called the *'handy man'* because tools were found with its fossil remains. Its brain size rose from 500 cc to 800 cc during its evolutionary life and the shape of its brain suggests that it might have developed some speech capabilities. With the height of about 5 feet, it weighed around 100 pounds. Some scientists believe that Habilis is not separate species, but it is late Australopithecus or an early Homo Erectus [8].

Homo Erectus: It lived between 1.8 million and 300,000 years ago. Being a successful species for about a million and a half years, its brain expanded from 800 cc to about 1200 cc. It developed speech capabilities and made tools, weapons for hunting and discovered fire for cooking. Such needs made him to travel out of Africa into China and South-east Asia and, in the process, developed clothing for northern cold climates. Like Habilis, it had large jaw bone with huge molars, no chin, thick brow ridges, and a long low skull [9].

Homo Sapiens: Homo Erectus was followed by three successive species of Homo Sapiens; Archiac, Neanderthal, and Sapiens;

1. Homo Sapiens Archiac is considered as a bridge between Homo Erectus and Homo Sapiens during the period between 500,000 to 150,000 years. Its brain averaged about 1200 cc and had definite speech capability. Its skull was more rounded and had smaller features, such as its molars and brow ridges were smaller. The skeleton was well proportioned but stronger than the modern man [10].
2. Homo Sapiens Neanderthals lived in Europe and the Middle

East between 150,000 and 35,000 years ago. It coexisted with Homo Sapiens Archaic and early Homo Sapiens Sapiens. It is not known whether it was of the same species and disappeared into the Homo Sapiens Sapiens gene pool or was crowded out of existence by the Homo Sapiens Sapiens. Recent DNA studies have indicated that the Neanderthal was an entirely different species and did not merge into the Homo Sapiens Sapiens gene pool [11].

3. Homo Sapiens Sapiens first appeared about 120,000 years ago and evolved into a form almost indistinguishable from modern man around 40,000 years ago. There has been no change in his appearance ever since. The brain of the modern man has an average size of 1350 cc [12].

The last 40,000 years are important in history of mankind as this period is filled with controversies for Homo Sapeins Sapiens in mythologies, religions and science. The controversies became prominent because during this period non-recordable pre-history events were separated from recordable historic events. The stories of separation have been especially highlighted in the last three centuries of geological upsurge and technological developments as a result of industrial revolution. In simple words, there are no written records from human prehistory as clear techniques for dating were not well-developed until the 19th century [13].

Before going further, let us see what the Sufis say about history of mankind so far. They take their understanding from Quran and authentic Ahadith. As mentioned before, they insist that Quran is not a book of science or history but is a book of 'signs' presented by a prophet 1400 years ago. He had no conventional education but developed immense spiritual powers through meditation in solitudes in 'Ghar-e-Hira' (cave of Hira) for forty years. According to Sufis, Quran is known to have several layers of understanding. It is for this reason its readers take scholastic views according to their understanding and explain them accordingly.

Thus one finds scholars like Haroon Yahya, who is against theory of evolution, proving his point of views by giving verses from Quran, while same or similar verses are presented by other

scholars like Hassan El-Najjar who support evolution according to his understanding. The latter group suggests that universe was created by God who let it go through a process of evolution through natural selection without interference.

Sufis take slightly different view. They believe that Singularity was exploded by *'Kun'* of God and then let it pass through a 'controlled' evolution. By controlled evolution they mean that God acts as a force letting species go through process of evolution and in the process some species get extinct while other progress according to their surviving capabilities. The evolutionists call it intervention by 'nature' labelling it as 'survival of the fittest.' So in a way both evolutionists and Sufis are on the same page except they give different name to the intervening force.

Sufis get their understanding from the same verses of Quran, the other theosophists get with exception that Sufis read them in spiritual realm. For example, they quote a verse which in its unique style challenges those who do not believe in human's pre-life of non-existence, *"Doth not man remember that We created him before, when he was naught?"* [14] How did human appear from 'non-existence' to 'existence' and then went through evolutionary stages? It is explained by the Sufis through verses of Quran. They put forward those verses in chronological order of human development as part and parcel of evolution of solar system and earth.

For example;

1. Quran says human was created from dust. This is the earliest part of history when life did not exist and our solar system was in the form of swirling dust."*And of His signs is this: He created you of dust, and behold you human beings, ranging widely!"* [15]
2. Then the dust started to solidify turning into something like clay which floated in space with thundering noise. Pointing at this phase of evolution Quran states, *"We created man from sounding clay, from mud molded into shape"* [16]. Sufis call this phase of human development as 'Jamadaat'.(matter)

3. The evolution continued as the earth was taking rocky and mountainous shape covered with clay. Quran at this stage talks of man created out of clay, *"Allah is He who has made everything He created better, and He began the creation of the human (being) out of clay"* [17]. Or it says, *"He is Who has created you from clay, then he spent a term of time (away from you), and (it is) a specific term he determined. Yet, you doubt (his ability)!"* [18] The important point in this verse is that it uses the Arabic word *'bada'a'* which means that human creation happened in a process that had a beginning not just at once thus pointing at evolutionary process. The same meaning is found in another verse which says, *"Were We then fatigued with the first creation? Yet are they in doubt with regard to a new creation"* [19]. All these evolutionary phases are part of pre-life state of 'Jamadaat' (matter) described by Sufis
4. As the evolution carried on, water and seas appeared on the scene. The geologists tell us that life appeared in water at the bottom of sea in the sticky clay of 'Primordial Soup'. As we discussed in early chapters, Quran also talks of life appearing in water at the bottom of sea where an impermeable barrier was created between 'sweet and sour water' identical to cell membrane. That was the beginning of life of unicellular organism. Quran refers to that phase of evolution when it says, *"...and We made every living thing out of water? Will they not then believe?* [20] Talking about the life in sticky clay of 'Primordial Soup' Quran states,"*...Indeed, We created men from sticky clay"* [21]. Or when it says, *"We created the human being from stinking, smooth, (and wet) clay."* [22]
5. The evolution continued and water started to play important role in the origin of human life. Quran mentions it clearly by saying,"*And He it is Who hath created man from water"* [23].
6. As the evolution continued, life in water flourished and in the process plants appeared. Sufis link plant life as part of their life in evolutionary process and call it 'Nabataat'. They refer it to Quranic verse which says, *"And Allah has caused you to*

grow out of the earth like plants" [24].

7. Then, Quran talks of creation of animal life in water, categorizing animals and taking them out of water onto the surface. Sufis link their life to this phase of evolution calling it 'Haywanaat'. "*Allah has created every animal out of water. Of them (is a category which) walks upon its belly, (another which) walks upon two legs, and (a third which) walks upon four. Allah creates what He wills. Allah is Able to do everything (he wants)"* [25]
   It is this factor or force in process of evolution which Sufis call 'Allah' and evolutionists call 'The Nature'.
8. These three stages of human evolution from 'matter' to 'plant' and unto 'animal' has been mentioned by the great Sufi poet, Rumi in his 'Masnavi' when he says,

"I died from minerality and became vegetable;
And From vegetativeness I died and became animal.
I died from animality and became man.
Then why fear disappearance through death?
Next time I shall die
Bringing forth wings and feathers like angels;
After that, soaring higher than angels -
What you cannot imagine, I shall be that" (26].

Thus, it seems Sufis are inclined in their beliefs towards evolution of human. Before going further let us recap it up to this point by quoting Quranic verse which states, "*It is He Who created you, fashioned you perfectly, and made you with the right proportions (straightened you up, to walk in an upright position)"* [27].

In this verse Quran uses three verbs; first 'khalaqa for creation; second 'sawwa' for fashioning perfectly; and third 'adala' for making walk in upright position. First is linked with living cell; second is pointing at change from unicellular prokaryote organism

to multi-cellular eukaryote animal; and third is hinting at human departure from animal phase by walking straight as Homo Erectus.

Ibn Kathir explains this verse using a Hadith from Prophet Muhammad which says that God created humans in the best image and the right proportion and made them walk in a balanced way, in an upright position, which allowed them to walk between the two cold places such as North and South Poles [28]. This is a direct reference to the Homo erectus, which marked a major departure of humans from their closest kinship in the primate family. It also points to evolutionary progress which made humans to explore, migrate, and ultimately live in all regions of the earth between the two cold areas [29].

After separating hominids from animals and starting upright walk on two legs as Homo erectus, two further evolutionary changes appeared. First, alteration in structure of its skull, second expansion of its brain. These two changes played essential evolutionary role in separating humans (Homo Sapiens sapiens) from hominids (Homo erectus). The expanded brain of modern man (Homo sapiens sapiens) became vital towards achieving knowledge and using it to his benefit.

With passage of time and in process of evolution modern man developed coordination between 'hearing', 'seeing' and 'speaking' to help attain knowledge. According to human development 'hearing' appears in the womb followed by concentration of sight a few days after birth and learning to speak a few months later. The Quran mentions these essentials of knowledge and place them according to their embryological development and tie them to heart instead of the intellect to give it spiritual uplift when it says, "*Then He shaped him (in due proportions), and breathed in him of His Spirit, and made for you hearing, sight, and hearts; little thanks you give*" [30].

Some Sufis see a link between hominid (Homo erectus) and modern man (Homo sapiens sapiens) by referring Quranic verse which says, "*O mankind, what has deceived you concerning your Lord, the Generous, Who created you, proportioned you, and*

balanced you? In whatever form (image) He willed, He put you together (assembled you)" [32]. They argue that the Arabic verb, 'rakkaba', used in this verse can be translated into 'putting together' or 'assembling'. Thus, the word may refer to assembling human beings by using genetic materials from other organisms, in order for humans to be better than their closest animal relatives, the primates. They compare such 'assembling' by God, to the scientists using genetic engineering and introducing changes in existing organisms.

Ibn Kathir explains the Arabic word 'rakkaba' by saying that the fertilized egg carries all the genetic characteristics of humans all the way from the first creation [33]. Ekremah, Abu Saleh, and Quotada added that some people may even have a feature of animals as their faces may look like monkeys pointing to the fact that human being is the product of a long line of genetic traits [34].

Tracing the history of mankind further and referring to Quranic verses, Sufis say that a competition based on knowledge took place between various types of livings including the humans. It was won by human making him the viceroy of planet earth to govern it according to his intellectual acumen [35]. *"And We created you (humans, in plural form), then fashioned you (made you in the image you are, also addressing humans in plural form), then said to the angels: Prostrate to Adam! And they prostrated, all except Iblis (another name for Satan), who was not of those who made prostration"* [36].

A few points are important in this verse;

First, God uses humans in plural with regards to their creation (khalaqa) and fashioning their image (sawwara) but when it comes to wining the competition, God mentions one human-Adam.

Second, the word 'then' is used between 'khalaqnkum' and 'sawarnakum' which indicates period of time between the two events during which humans went through stages of creating life, then passing through its increasing complexity and finally bringing it to the human stage which is higher in rank than other livings.

Third, the word 'then' is used again between 'sawarnakum' and ordering to accept Adam's superiority which shows another period

was given to Adam amongst humans in which he acquired knowledge. This is confirmed in another Quranic verse which says,*"He taught Adam all the names. Then He introduced (some intelligent beings) to the angels, asking them to tell Him the names of these beings, if the angels were true to their claim (that they more deserved to be His deputies on earth"* [37].

Fourth, it also shows that human superiority on planet earth is related to knowledge because of which Adam won the competition. After wining, he was given tasks to perform his duties with responsibility. This verse gives support to the argument of creating humans through stages of creation, fashioning, and education [38].

After human was isolated from other hominids and became a 'modern man (Homo sapiens sapiens) and before he took the responsibility of becoming viceroy of planet earth at the end of this competition, Quran gives some details of his embryological development. This type of knowledge was not known 1400 years ago. It starts by saying, *"We placed it as a nutfah (fertilized egg) in a safe (deep) lodging; Then, We created the nutfah into an alaqa (a fertilized egg sticking to the womb sucking nutrients from it like a leach). Then, We created the alaqa into mudghah (a little lump, like a chewed substance). Then, We created the mudghah into bones. Then, We clothed the bones with flesh. Then, We produced it (the human being) as another creation. So blessed be Allah, the Best of creators!* [39]

A 'nutfah' is the Arabic word for a fertilized egg-a zygote. While 'alaqa' is the Arabic word for a leech symbolizing a fertilized egg sticking to the womb wall and sucking nutrients like a leech. This type of medical information about developmental stages of foetus in uterus has only come to light recently. Sufis link this information to the spiritual knowledge and wisdom of Muhammad who had no formal education.

In this way, Quran gives step by step development of human from the time when earth was in the form of dust to the final stage of human development as embryo in uterus. As the notion of time in Quranic knowledge is cosmological and not what we have

created for ourselves on planet earth, these steps at times are millions years apart. Once we understand this point, it becomes easy to understand human's social and cultural development as described by the naturalists such as Sir David Attenborough who worked hard in investigative field of fossils related to prehistory periods and historic eras.

Lastly, after bringing the evolutionary process to modern man (Home sapiens sapiens) Quran hints at spiritual insight of human being by stating "*O humans! Be pious (careful of your duty) to your Lord, Who created you from a single soul, and from it He created its mate, and from them He has spread a multitude of men and women*" [40].

As 'soul' plays vital role in spiritual journey, this verse points at spiritual development of human beings in future. This aspect of human is important for uplift of societies at local, regional, and global levels. This topic will be discussed later in the relevant chapter.

Now that we have found minimum differences about the history of mankind between the scientists and Sufis, let us proceed further and follow humans' cultural and social development as presented by the naturalists through their investigative work on fossil finds from prehistory and cryptographic records from historic periods. It is pertinent to note that the end of prehistory which is related to the time when relevant written historical records as hieroglyphics became source of information, varied from region to region. For example, it is generally accepted that Egyptian prehistory ended around 3200 BC, whereas in New Guinea the end of the prehistoric era is set at around 1900 AD. It was the same story in Europe and elsewhere [41].

It is also pertinent to mention that knowledge of prehistory became important part of 'evolutionary psychology' which deals with human characteristics as adapted in the prehistoric environment during the long Palaeolithic period [42]. According to geologic findings, the actual human prehistory started in the Palaeolithic Era, or "Early Stone Age" around 2 million years ago

when hominid started making crude stone tools. It progressed successively during the period of Homo sapiens sapiens passing through the 'New Stone Age' of Neolithic Era at the end of the Ice Age around 10,000 years ago, and ended around 5,000 years later when the Bronze Age began.

Prior to the appearance of Homo sapiens sapiens the hominids changed from being herbivorous to mainly meat eater and hunting became its major means of survival. Accordingly, the defensive weapon of hominid-the club, changed to offensive weapon of man-the spear and flint. It was during the period of Homo sapiens sapiens, when humans left caves and settled in huts made of branches, stones, or bricks, depending on the available resources. In this way, the first isolated human settlements appeared as gathering of small huts in shape of small villages which could easily be defended.

One of the most important events of the prehistory was the Agricultural Revolution which started during the Neolithic Age between 8000 and 5000 BC. As part of and as a result of that revolution following changes appeared in the history of mankind;

1. Humans started taming, domesticating and breeding animals and growing grains for feeding purposes. As all this needed water, the settlements appeared along the river banks; the major being along the rivers Euphrates and Tigris in Mesopotamia, around 3500 BC [43], river Nile in Egypt around 3300 BC [44], and the Indus River in India around 3300 BC [45]. Similar habitations appeared along the banks of major rivers in China.
2. As the sizes of settlements increased they changed into towns and cities. In this way, elaborate cities grew up with high levels of social and economic complexity seemingly different from each others because of infrequent links between the people living there. As part of evolutionary processes, the need to store food between seasons enabled people in division of labour. They started getting differentiated according to their trades such as farmers, shepherds and craftsmen etc. They

exchanged food, pottery, baskets and various items in markets as part of barter trade. Such trade not only made way to expand the sizes of villages, towns and cities but it also increased the chances of creating human classes thus giving various shapes to societies and civilizations. The growing complexity of societies necessitated systems of accounting, which led to writing. and that became not only essential part of trade to meet the needs of societies but also an essential tool for record keeping paving the way for converting prehistory era into historical period [46].

3. Agriculture being the main source of living, people linked their timetable of days and months of the year with sowing and harvesting of crops which paved the way for making calendars as discussed earlier.
4. The use of clay appeared when Neolithic people started using it for dwelling, making clay pots, and human or animal figurines. They not only used pots for storing grains, food items or water but they also started painting them with images of humans, animals and plants. That was the leisurely and aesthetic aspect of human evolution [47].
5. From clay they went for wooden technology and started using sticks to catch fish in shallow waters. With passage of time, they made the first 'vessels' in shape of canoes built of carved tree trunks or skiffs made of scaffolds of tree branches covered by tarred skins. In this way, they started using them for fishing and navigation through shallow waters [48].
6. Metallurgy was another important item that appeared at the tail end of Stone Age. Around 8000 years ago, the first processed metals were copper, tin, silver and gold. Near the end of the last Stone Age, about 6,300 years ago, people from Indus Valley to Central Asia started to process copper. Thus metallurgy brought gradual improvement in the living styles of humans as they started to make new metal tools, adornments and weapons ending the era of the 'Stone Age' around 5,000 years ago [49].

7. Thus stone as major tool was replaced in the following millenniums by bronze opening the gate to the 'Bronze Age'. Bronze became part of life used in agriculture, social life and warfare. Up until around 3000 BC, agricultural settlements had been almost completely dependent on stone tools. Sometimes in that millennium, copper and bronze tools, decorations and weapons took over the stone tools in Eurasia. Invention of writing is also linked with the beginning of the Bronze Age [50].

In the following centuries roughly corresponding to the "Axial Age" at the beginning of 7th century BC, iron tools and weapons replaced the bronze in the Eastern Mediterranean region, Middle East and China. The era saw not only a set of independent transformative philosophical ideas but religious too in various locations. For example;

- In philosophical fields, Socrates [51], Plato [52], Aristotle [53], and other philosophers laid foundations of Ancient Greek philosophy in the 5th century BC.
- In 6th century BC; Chinese Confucianism as philosophy and Taoism as spirituality [54]; Indian Buddhism and Jainism as religio-spirituality; Persian Zoroastrianism and Jewish Monotheism as religions were getting organized.

In this way, the history of mankind came out of pre-historic period and entered the historic period bringing theology, philosophy and spirituality in social life of modern man.

This brings us to the topics of;

- Mankind and Theology,
- Mankind and Philosophy,
- Mankind and Spirituality.

Let us take them one by one.

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